



— OFFICIAL —
**AWARDS &
RECOGNITION
SUMMARY
HANDBOOK**

*Leave It Better
Than You Found It*



**NEW YORK STUDENT
SUMMER CHALLENGE**

PRESENTED BY

Frantz Coutard



◆ PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY EDITION ◆

OFFICIAL AWARDS & RECOGNITION HANDBOOK

Leave It Better Than You Found It

This handbook summarizes the official award categories and recognition pathways for students, schools, principals, and teachers in the Leave It Better Than You Found It New York Student Summer Challenge.

OFFICIAL USE

For official competition, school, and community use The handbook is written to support clear understanding, consistent expectations, and fair administration.

Publication Information

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Leave It Better Than You Found It New York Student Summer Challenge

Presented by Frantz Coutard

Official Edition - 2026

USE OF THIS HANDBOOK

This handbook summarizes the official award categories and recognition pathways for students, schools, principals, and teachers in the Leave It Better Than You Found It New York Student Summer Challenge.

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Introduction: Awards at a Glance

The Leave It Better Than You Found It New York Student Summer Challenge recognizes excellence at every level of the educational community. The program rewards not only individual student achievement, but also the educators and schools that create opportunities for students to learn, lead, and serve.

\$10K
student scholarship pool

\$25K
school STEM grant

3
major educator/school awards

2026
official competition cycle

OFFICIAL PRINCIPLE
Students are rewarded for the strength of their ideas. Teachers are rewarded for the lives they influence. Principals are rewarded for the cultures they build. Schools are rewarded for the opportunities they create.

Chapter 1: Student Scholarships

Objectives	Key Takeaways
- Understand the student scholarship purpose. - Clarify who selects student winners. - Identify the forms of student recognition available.	- Student winners are selected by Official Independent Judges. - Scholarships recognize the strength of student ideas and solutions. - Student recognition is separate from school, teacher, and principal recognition.

Scholarship Pool

Student scholarships may total up to \$10,000. Students compete by identifying real problems facing local businesses and developing practical, innovative solutions.

Possible Student Awards

- First Place Scholarship
- Second Place Scholarship

- Third Place Scholarship
- Statewide Recognition
- Internship Opportunities
- Career Networking Opportunities

DETERMINED BY

Official Independent Judges using the official judging rubric.

Chapter 2: School STEM Grant

Objectives	Key Takeaways
- Explain the purpose of the School STEM Grant. - Clarify how the award is determined. - Show how school-wide participation matters.	- The School STEM Grant is not determined by judges. - It is calculated by the Official Competition Platform. - Verified participation and engagement data are central to the award process.

Grand Prize

The School STEM Grant may provide up to \$25,000 to the winning school. This award recognizes outstanding student participation, teacher engagement, and school-wide commitment to innovation and community problem-solving.

IMPORTANT DISTINCTION

This award is not determined by judges. It is calculated automatically by the Official Competition Platform using verified participation and engagement data.

Determined by

Official Competition Platform.

Chapter 3: Teacher Impact Award

Objectives	Key Takeaways
- Define the Teacher Impact Award. - Explain how teachers strengthen eligibility. - Position the award as educational impact recognition.	- The award recognizes educators who encourage participation and mentor students. - It is not based only on having the highest-scoring student. - The platform evaluates verified participation and engagement data.

Award Purpose

The Teacher Impact Award recognizes an educator who demonstrates exceptional commitment to encouraging student participation, mentoring young innovators, and helping students successfully complete the challenge.

Teachers Strengthen Their Opportunity By

- Encouraging students to register.
- Supporting students throughout the competition.
- Helping students successfully complete projects.
- Creating opportunities for as many eligible students as possible.
- Promoting innovation, leadership, and community engagement within their classrooms.

NAMING RECOMMENDATION

For a more polished public-facing award title, the prize may be presented as the Teacher Impact Retreat, Leave It Better Teacher Excellence Award, Innovation in Education Award, or Teacher Leadership Experience.

Determined by: Official Competition Platform.

Chapter 4: Principal Leadership Award

Objectives	Key Takeaways
- Explain principal recognition. - Identify leadership actions that support recognition. - Clarify how the award is determined.	- Principals are recognized for the cultures they build. - Leadership is measured through verified platform activity. - The award recognizes school-wide engagement and support.

The Principal Leadership Award recognizes school leaders who create a culture of innovation, encourage teacher participation, and support meaningful student engagement throughout the competition.

Principals Strengthen Their Opportunity By

- Claiming the School Dashboard.
- Encouraging teacher participation.
- Promoting student involvement.
- Supporting school-wide engagement.
- Fostering a culture of innovation and community leadership.

Determined by: Official Competition Platform.

Chapter 5: Recognition Philosophy

Each award category has a distinct purpose and is determined through its own official evaluation process. Together, the awards recognize every level of educational leadership.

Award Category	Recognizes	Determined By
Student Scholarships	Strength of student ideas, innovation, and solutions	Official Independent Judges
School STEM Grant	School-wide opportunity, participation, and engagement	Official Competition Platform

Teacher Impact Award	Educator mentorship, encouragement, and student support	Official Competition Platform
Principal Leadership Award	School culture, leadership, and participation support	Official Competition Platform

FINAL GUIDING PRINCIPLE

A strong competition recognizes more than one kind of excellence. Students innovate. Teachers inspire. Principals lead. Schools create opportunity. Together, they strengthen communities and prepare the next generation of leaders.

Quick Reference Guide

- Student Scholarships: up to \$10,000, determined by Official Independent Judges.
- School STEM Grant: up to \$25,000, calculated by the Official Competition Platform.
- Teacher Impact Award: recognizes educational impact and student support.
- Principal Leadership Award: recognizes leadership, culture, and school-wide engagement.
- Sponsors support opportunity but do not determine award recipients.
- Every category is evaluated through the official process assigned to that award.